

Campus Pride Index: A Guide to LGBTQ+ Inclusive Colleges

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Section 1. Introduction

- This project analyzes U.S. college campus pride index ratings, enrollment size, and institutional characteristics to identify patterns in student inclusivity and institutional scale. The goal is to help prospective students and education stakeholders understand which types of campuses provide the best student experience and which institutional factors may influence ratings.
- Click [here](#) for Tableau Public Link or copy and paste the URL below
 - https://public.tableau.com/views/Foster_Final_CampusPrideIndexRating/DataStoryGuide?:language=en-US&publish=yes&:sid=&:redirect=auth&:display_count=n&:origin=viz_share_link
 - [Click here for GitHub Link](#)

Section 2. Data Description

- The Campus Pride Index dataset contains information about U.S. colleges and universities, including inclusivity ratings, enrollment size, campus type (public or private), and minority-serving institution status. The MEI (Municipality Equality Index) dataset includes MEI ratings and states. The MEI is the comprehensive nationwide assessment of LGBTQ+ equality in the areas of municipal policies, laws and services. I used only the *overall* MEI rating. Both datasets are from 2024. I combined both datasets into one Excel file.
- Columns include:
 - College Name
 - Rating (pride index score and MEI score)
 - Enrollment (number of students)
 - Public or Private status
 - Minority-Serving Institution indicator
 - Location information
 - Community Type (urban – rural)
- The dataset contains 238 rows and 22 columns, with each row representing one campus.
- Data Sources:
 - [Campus Pride Index](#)
 - [MEI Data](#) and [MEI website](#)

Section 3. Data Cleaning Strategies

- Data cleaning was performed in Excel and Tableau. There were two sheets for the Pride Index Excel files so I combined them into one. NA was changed to null fields. Boolean fields such as Minority-Serving Institution status were standardized. Cities and their respective states were split and state abbreviations were standardized. I added the MEI data to the Pride Index data using state as the key. No major cleaning was required.

Section 4. Clean Dataset

- The cleaned dataset contains 238 campuses with complete enrollment and rating information. Each row represents one campus, allowing comparison across institutional type, size, student inclusivity, and national MEI state rating.

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N	O	P	Q	R	S	T	U	V
1	campus_name	campus_location	rating	community_type	number_of_students	public	private	doctoral	masters	baccalaureate	community_college	residential	nonresidential	liberal_arts	technical	religious	military	hbcu	hispanic_serving	aapi_serving	other_minority_serving	MEI
2	The University of Alabama at Tuscaloosa, AL		4.5	small city	38000	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	0
3	University of Central Arkansas, Conway, AR		2	small city	12000	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	0
4	University of Arkansas at Little Rock, AR		2.5	medium city	6712	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	0
5	Northern Arizona University, Flagstaff, AZ		4.5	small city	29000	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	0
6	California State University Long Beach, CA		4.5	medium city	36846	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	48
7	University of La Verne, La Verne, CA		2.5	small city	8600	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	48
8	California State University Northridge, CA		4.5	large urban city	36000	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	48
9	Napa Valley College, Napa, CA		4	small city	5000	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	48
10	San Diego State University, San Diego, CA		5	large urban city	32000	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	48
11	California State University Chico, CA		4	medium city	16251	TRUE	NA	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	48
12	University of California Irvine, CA		3.5	medium city	29000	NA	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	48
13	San Francisco State University, San Francisco, CA		3.5	large urban city	29905	TRUE	NA	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	48
14	Dominican University, San Rafael, CA		3	small city	1531	NA	TRUE	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	48
15	Skyline College, San Bruno, CA		3	small city	5599	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	48
16	California State Polytechnic University Pomona, CA		3.5	medium city	23717	TRUE	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	48
17	Diablo Valley College, Pleasant Hill, CA		1.5	small city	7854	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	48
18	Butte College, Oroville, CA		3.5	small town	4816	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	48
19	Norco College, Norco, CA		3	small town	10000	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	48
20	Otis College of Arts and Sciences, Los Angeles, CA		4	large urban city	1100	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	48
21	California State University Bakersfield, CA		3.5	medium city	7000	TRUE	NA	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	48
22	Woodbury University, Burbank, CA		3	medium city	1132	NA	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	48
23	University of Colorado Boulder, CO		5	small city	30000	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	36
24	University of Colorado Colorado Springs, CO		4.5	medium city	12017	TRUE	NA	TRUE	TRUE	TRUE	NA	TRUE	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	36

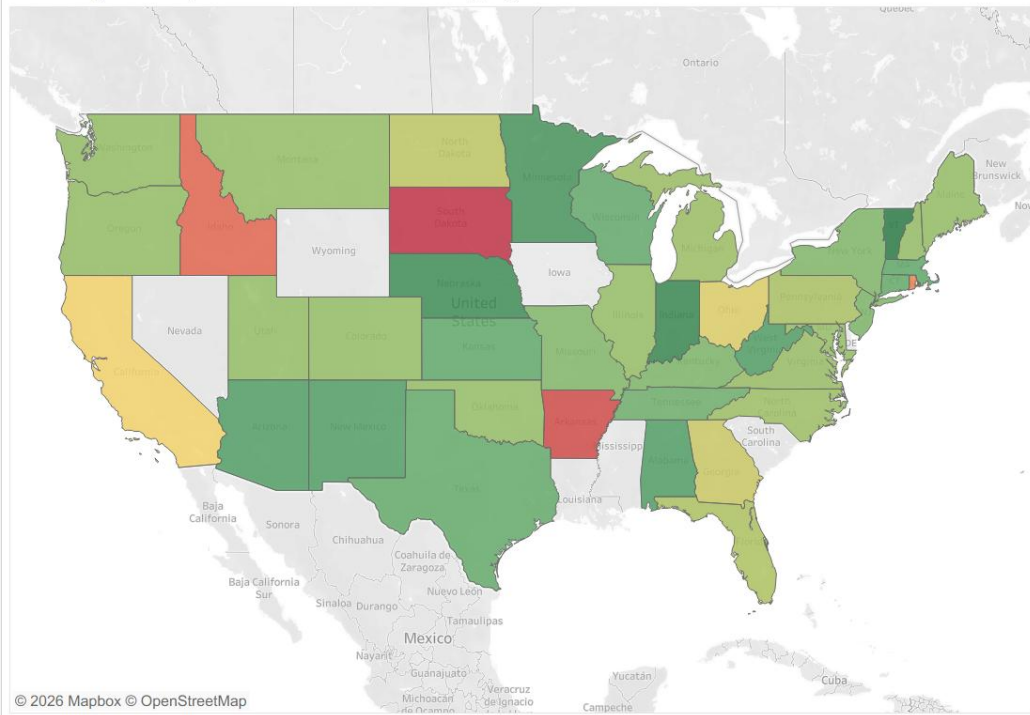
Section 5. Visualization Tools

- Tableau Public was used to create interactive visualizations and dashboards because it allows dynamic filtering, reference lines, and storytelling features that clearly communicate patterns in campus ratings and institutional characteristics.
- [Tableau Public Link](#)

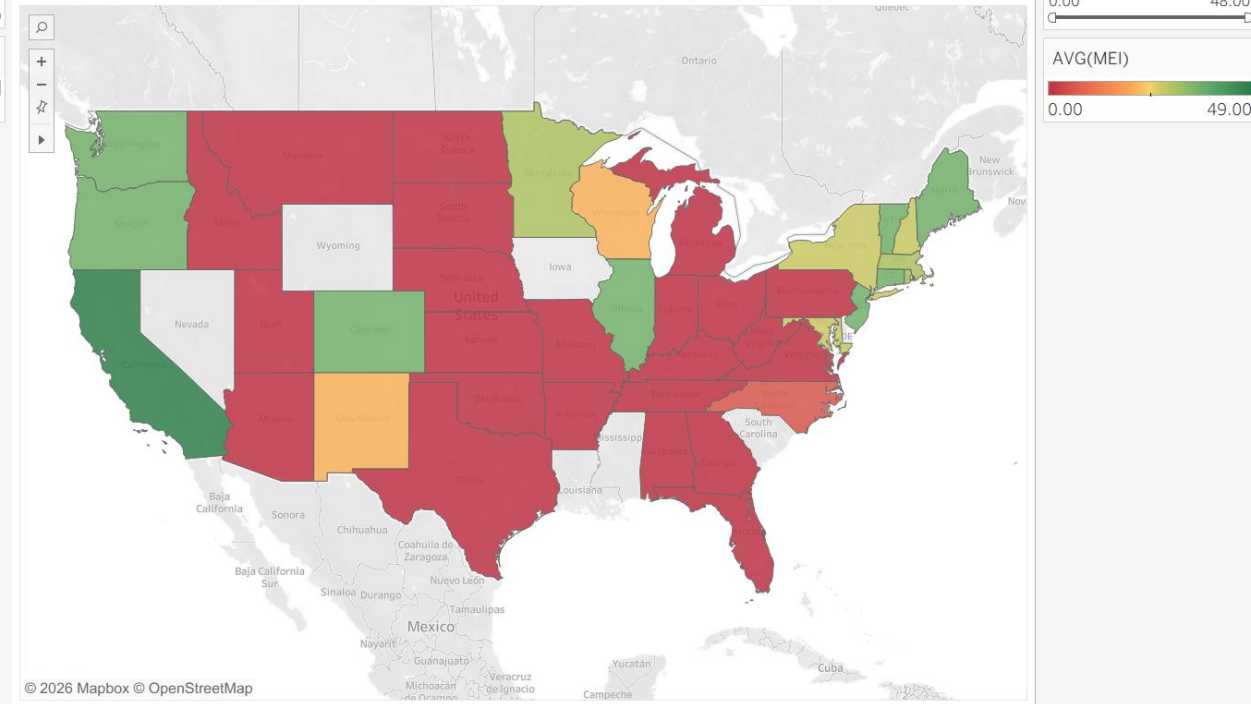
Section 6. Visualizations and Stories

- Goal 1: Do state-level LGBTQ+ policy environments relate to institutional inclusion ratings?

Average Campus Pride Index Rating by State



Average MEI Rating by State

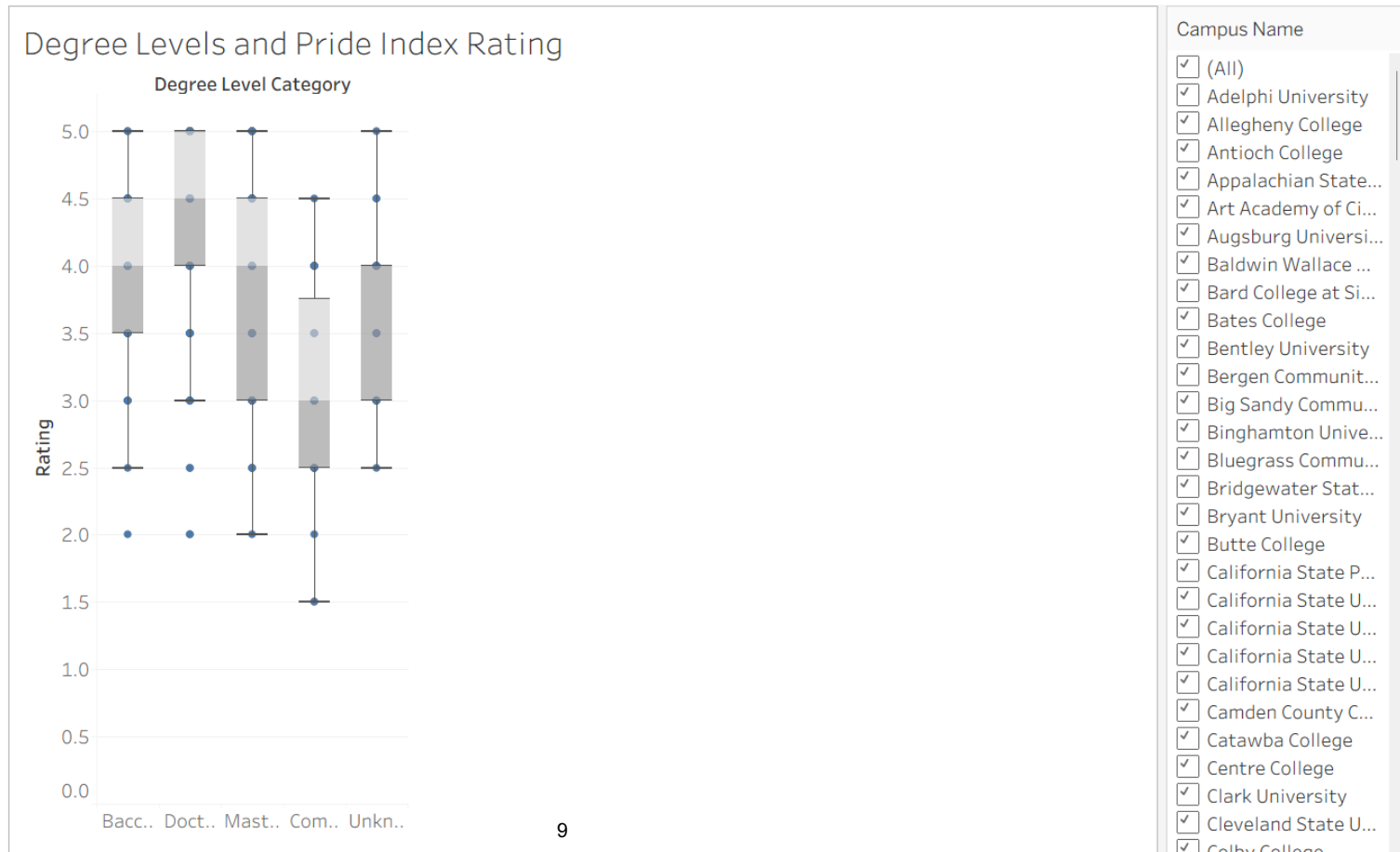


Section 6. Visualizations and Stories

- Do state-level LGBTQ policy environments relate to institutional inclusion ratings?
- Goal 1 Story: The Pride Index Rating map shows that many states fall in the green category, meaning campuses in those states generally have ratings of 4 stars or higher. Only a few states appear in red, with lower ratings between 2 and 2.5 stars. However, when compared to the MEI data, there is no clear correlation between campus Pride Index ratings and state-level policy scores. Many states appear red on the MEI map, indicating limited protective laws for LGBTQ+ individuals, even when their campus Pride Index ratings are relatively high. For example, California shows a moderate Pride Index rating but a high MEI score, while New Mexico has a high Pride Index rating but a lower MEI score. Additionally, several states with mid-range Pride Index ratings still have very low MEI scores, suggesting that campus inclusion efforts may not always reflect the broader legal and policy environment of the state.

Section 6. Visualizations and Stories

- Goal 2: Does institutional complexity (number of degree program levels offered) relate to higher ratings?



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- Does institutional complexity (number of degree program levels offered) relate to higher ratings?
- Goal 2 Story: Institutional complexity shows only modest differences in LGBTQ+ inclusion ratings. Doctoral institutions have the strongest overall ratings, with the middle 50% of campuses falling between 4 and 5 stars, indicating consistently high inclusion. Baccalaureate and master's institutions show slightly wider variation, though most campuses still fall between 3 and 4.5 stars. Community colleges have the lowest and widest range of ratings, suggesting more variability in inclusion efforts across those campuses. Overall, most institutions, regardless of degree level, maintain moderate to high Pride Index ratings.

Section 6. Visualizations and Stories

- Goal 3: Do minority-serving institutions show different inclusion rating patterns?

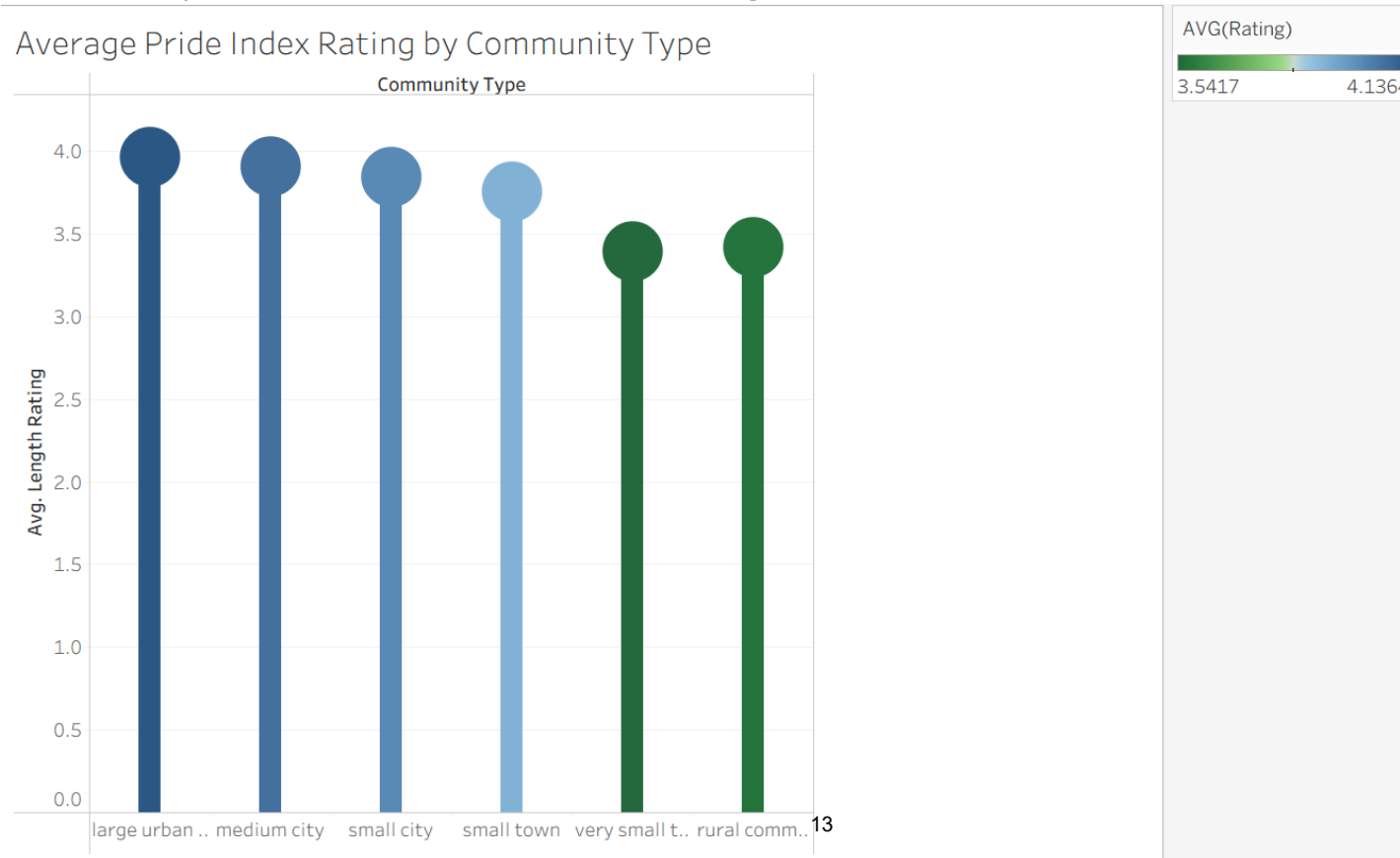


Section 6. Visualizations and Stories

- Do minority-serving institutions show different inclusion rating patterns?
- Goal 3 Story: Minority-serving institutions have Pride Index ratings comparable to, and in some cases slightly higher than, non-minority-serving campuses. AAPI-serving and other minority-serving campuses show the highest average rating at 4.17, followed by HBCUs at 4.0. Hispanic-serving institutions have a slightly lower average of 3.95 but remain close to the overall average. When grouped together, minority-serving campuses have an average rating of 3.99 compared to 3.98 for non-minority-serving campuses, indicating virtually no difference in overall inclusion ratings. Some campuses appear in multiple minority-serving categories, which explains similarities between certain averages. Overall, these results suggest that minority-serving institutions provide LGBTQ+ inclusive environments at levels comparable to other campuses, if not slightly higher.

Section 6. Visualizations and Stories

- Goal 4: Does community type (large urban city, medium city, small city, small town, very small town, rural) influence inclusion ratings?

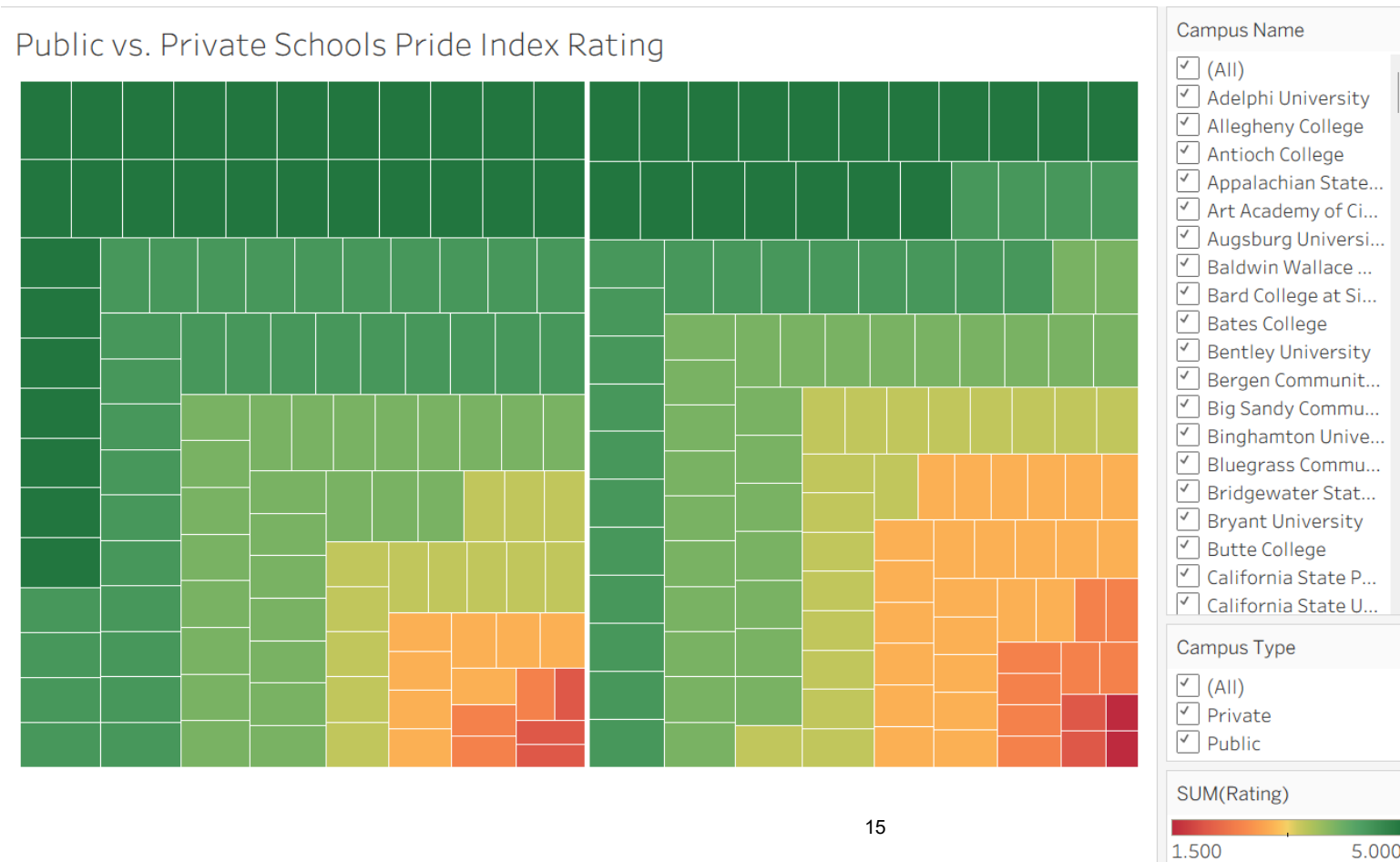


Section 6. Visualizations and Stories

- Does community type (urban - rural) influence inclusion ratings?
- Goal 4 Story: Campus Pride Index ratings generally decline as community size decreases. Large urban campuses have the highest average rating at 4.14, followed by medium cities (4.07) and small cities (4.01). Smaller towns and very small towns show lower ratings (3.92 and 3.54, respectively), with rural communities averaging 3.57. This pattern suggests that more urban campuses may provide slightly stronger LGBTQ+ inclusive environments, while smaller or rural campuses show greater variability and lower average inclusion ratings. Efforts to enhance LGBTQ+ inclusion may be particularly important for smaller towns and rural campuses, where average ratings are lower.

Section 6. Visualizations and Stories

- Goal 5: Do public and private institutions differ in LGBTQ+ inclusion ratings?

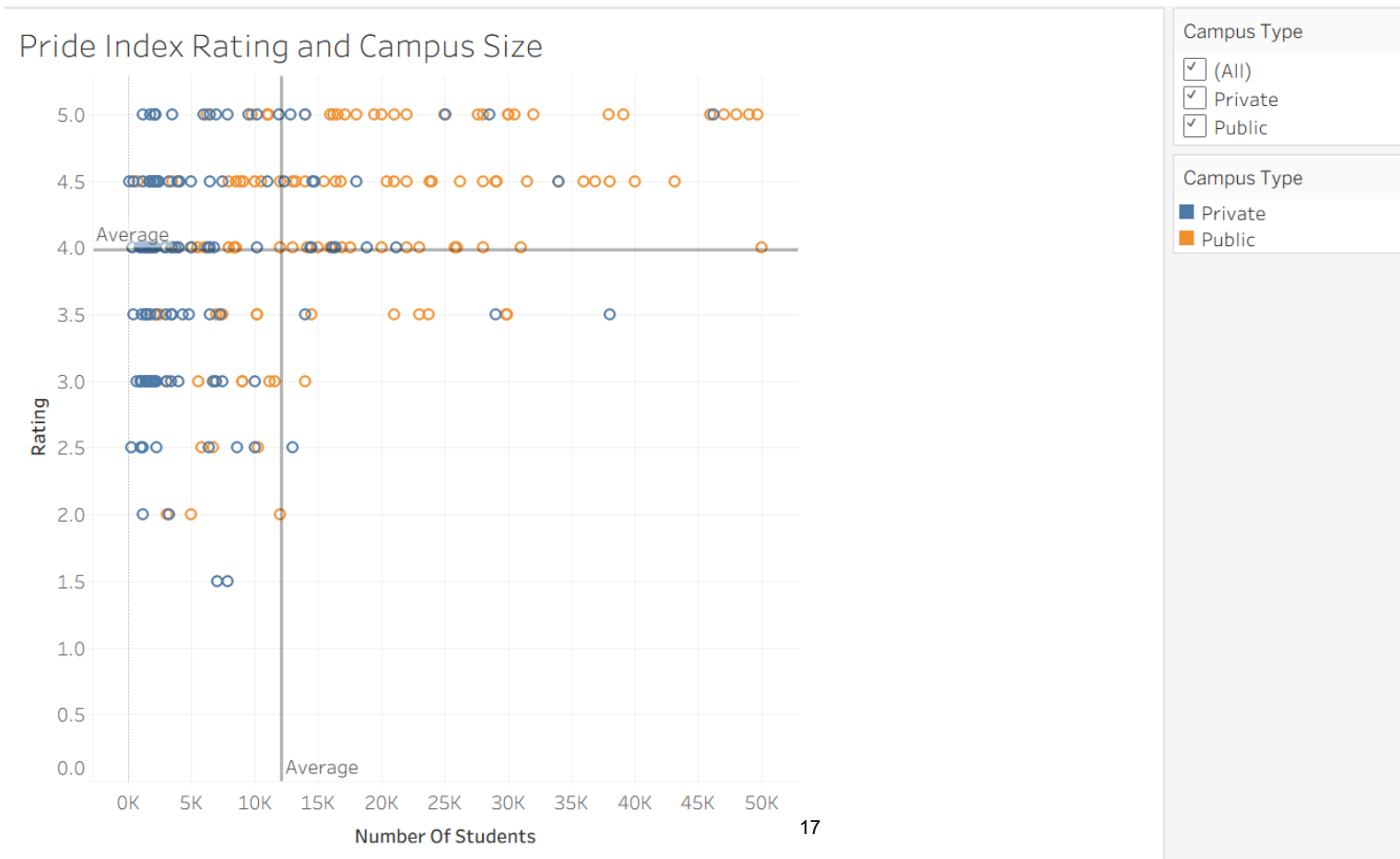


Section 6. Visualizations and Stories

- Do public and private institutions differ in LGBTQ+ inclusion ratings?
- Goal 5 Story: The Treemap shows Pride Index ratings across Public and Private institutions, with green indicating higher ratings and red indicating lower ratings. Public is the left treemap and private is the right treemap. Public colleges generally have higher ratings, with more campuses appearing in green and very few in red. In contrast, Private institutions show fewer high-rating campuses (green), more mid-range ratings (orange), and a small number of low-rating campuses (dark red). Dark green represents the maximum rating of 5, while dark red represents the minimum of 1.5. Overall, Public institutions appear to provide slightly more consistent and higher levels of LGBTQ+ inclusion compared to Private institutions.

Section 6. Visualizations and Stories

- Goal 6: What types of campuses offer both high ratings and manageable size?



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- What types of campuses offer both high ratings and manageable size?
- Goal 6 Story: The quadrant scatter plot compares campus Pride Index ratings to total enrollment, with reference lines for the average number of students and average rating. Private campuses tend to have smaller enrollments, and within that small size, ratings vary considerably. Some small private campuses have high Pride Index scores, while others are lower. Public campuses generally have larger enrollments and more consistently high ratings. Very few campuses fall into the low-rating, high-enrollment quadrant, indicating that large campuses rarely score poorly. Overall, small private campuses can be either high or low in inclusion, while large public campuses tend to maintain strong inclusion levels regardless of size.

Section 7. Conclusions

- Overall, the analysis shows that LGBTQ+ inclusive practices are present across a wide range of U.S. campuses, but patterns emerge when considering campus type, size, and context. Campus Pride Index ratings are generally high nationwide, even in states with limited policy protections, indicating that institutions often take initiative to foster inclusion regardless of the broader legal environment. Doctoral and baccalaureate institutions tend to have higher and more consistent ratings than community colleges or smaller degree-level institutions, while minority-serving campuses achieve ratings comparable to or slightly higher than non-minority-serving campuses. Larger urban campuses show higher average inclusion ratings, whereas smaller and rural campuses display more variability. Public institutions generally provide more consistent inclusion, while private campuses show greater variability. Finally, high inclusion is attainable across both small and large campuses, though small private campuses may require additional support to ensure consistently strong outcomes.
- These insights suggest that while many institutions are performing well, targeted strategies may help address variability among smaller, rural, or certain private campuses, and people can use this information to guide efforts that strengthen LGBTQ+ inclusion nationwide.